NOIS3 Challenge PM Guide: Workflows & Client Approvals

Oct 14, 2026 · @Jay

Purpose and how to use this guide

A NOIS3 challenge runs on ten workflows. This guide lists every step of each one, in order, and marks the points where the client must give input or approve. Use it at kickoff to build the schedule and set review windows, then as the checklist for each workflow while it runs.

- **Each workflow section** has a stepped diagram, then a table of its steps, sub-steps and what the client approves or provides.
- **The marketing version** is the Challenge Workflow Spec Sheet canvas. It holds the same workflows, so update both when a step changes.
- **Placeholders** in brackets, such as [X] business days, are set per task order at kickoff.

The approval model

Every step is one of three types, and the diagrams mark each with its own shape. Only approval gates stop work, so they are what the schedule is built around.

Step type	Marker in diagrams	What it means	Your job as PM
Client approval gate	Highlighted box, diamond	Work stops until the client signs off on a named deliverable	Name the deliverable, the reviewer and the review window, and put all three in the schedule
Client input	Box with circle	We need information, assets or a decision from the client, but no formal sign-off	Ask at kickoff or earlier, and chase before the step stalls
FedTech internal	Plain box, square	Our team owns the step from start to finish	Deliver it; the client sees the result at the next gate

Ground rules for client review

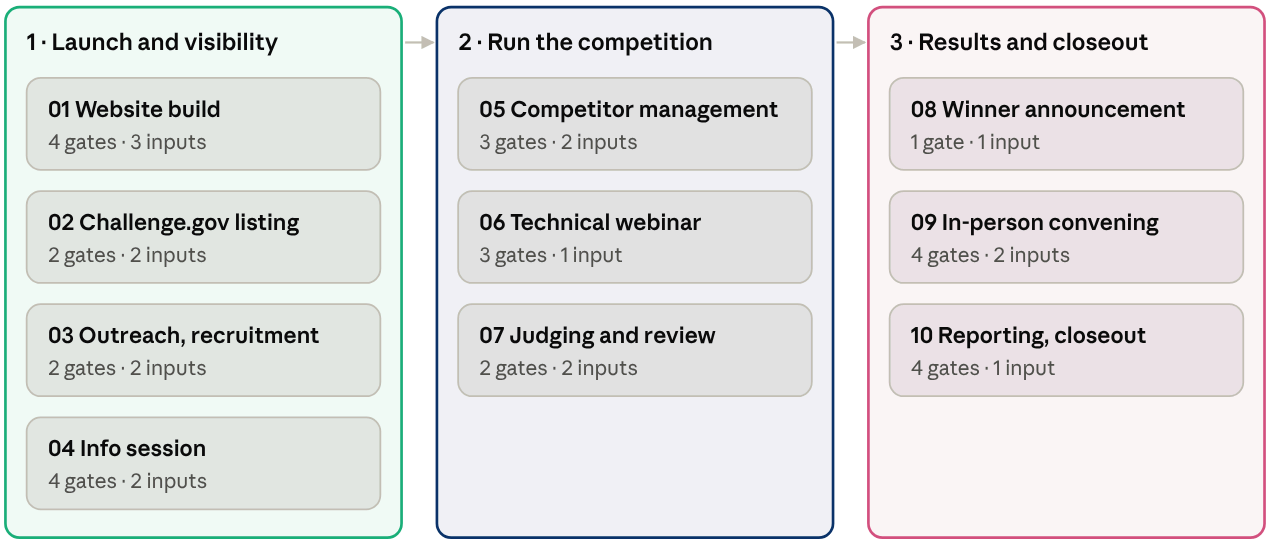
These seven rules apply to every workflow. Agree them with the COR at kickoff.

1. **Every gate has a named client reviewer and a fixed review window.** Both are set at kickoff and written into the schedule.
2. **One consolidated feedback round per gate.** A second round covers only changes we introduced while addressing the first.
3. **Nothing solver-facing goes public without its gate.** That covers site pages, Challenge.gov, promotions, decks, recordings and written answers.
4. **Anything said live is published in writing to every solver.** No team gains an advantage by attending a session.
5. **Section 508 accessibility is checked before anything goes public,** not fixed after launch.
6. **Rules, rubrics and platform are client-approved at least [30] days before each stage opens.** Confirm the lead time against each task order.
7. **Federal judges make every award decision.** FedTech, partners and SMEs advise and score; they never pick winners.

The challenge lifecycle at a glance

A full challenge runs ten workflows in three phases, with 29 approval gates and 18 client-input points in total. Reporting and closeout runs for the whole period of performance, even though it closes the sequence.

Ten workflows in three phases carry 29 approval gates



challenge lifecycle · 10 workflows in 3 phases

Each phase keeps its color through the workflow diagrams below, so you can tell at a glance which phase a workflow belongs to.

Workflow	FedTech lead	Client counterpart	When it runs
01 Website build	Challenge Operations Lead	COR + agency comms	Before launch; updated each stage
02 Challenge.gov listing	Challenge Operations Lead	COR + agency Challenge.gov manager	At launch; updated each stage
03 Outreach and recruitment	Outreach Lead	COR + agency comms	Launch through each stage close
04 Info session	Outreach Lead	COR + agency speakers	Shortly after launch

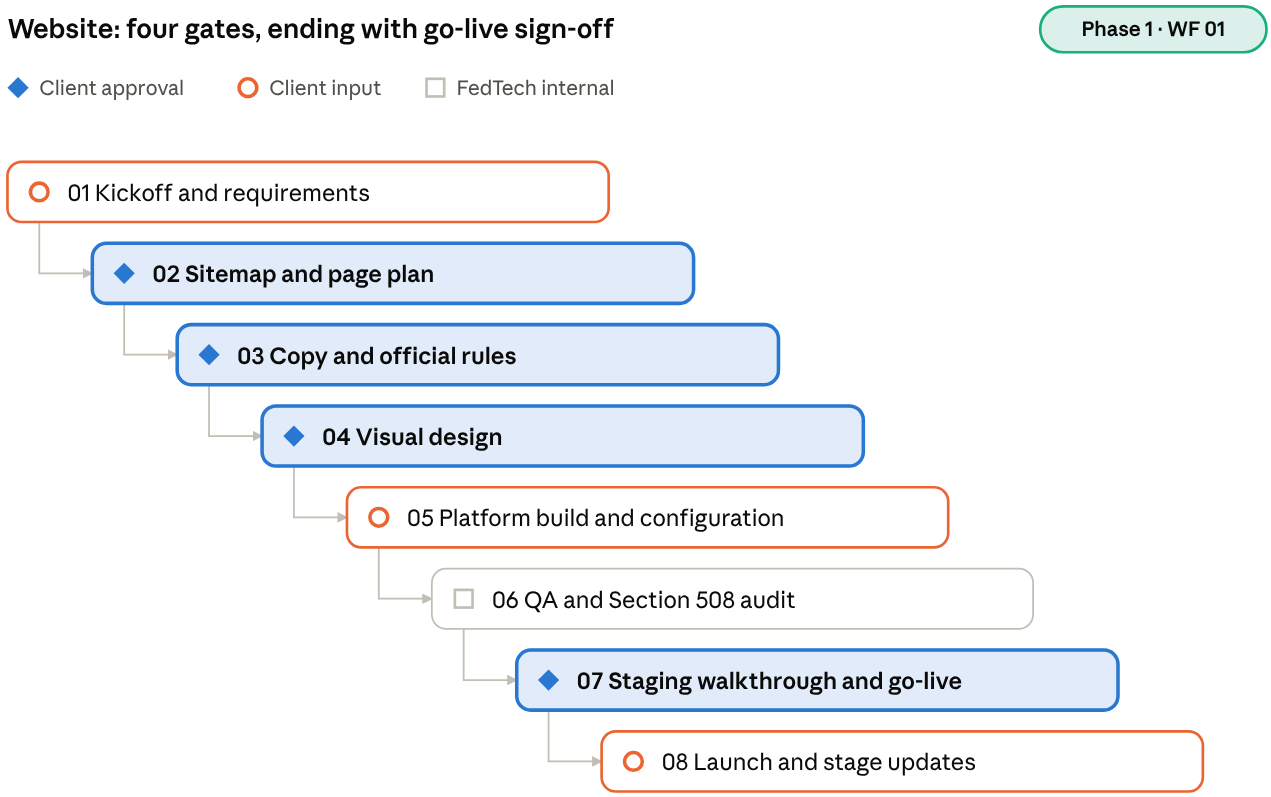
Workflow	FedTech lead	Client counterpart	When it runs
05 Competitor management	Challenge Operations Lead	COR	Launch to closeout
06 Technical webinar	Review Lead + Outreach Lead	COR + agency technical leads	Mid-stage
07 Judging and technical review	Review Lead	COR + federal judges	After each stage closes
08 Winner announcement	Outreach Lead	COR + agency public affairs	After each judging round
09 In-person convening	Outreach Lead	COR + program leadership	After final winners, if in scope
10 Reporting and closeout	Program Manager	COR	Whole period of performance

Phase 1: Launch and visibility

Phase 1 gets the challenge public and the right solvers registered. It holds 12 of the 29 gates, so most early schedule risk sits here.

01 Website build

The dedicated challenge site carries the agency's identity, not ours, and handles registration, eligibility screening, submissions and judging. Lead: Challenge Operations Lead. Client: COR and agency comms.



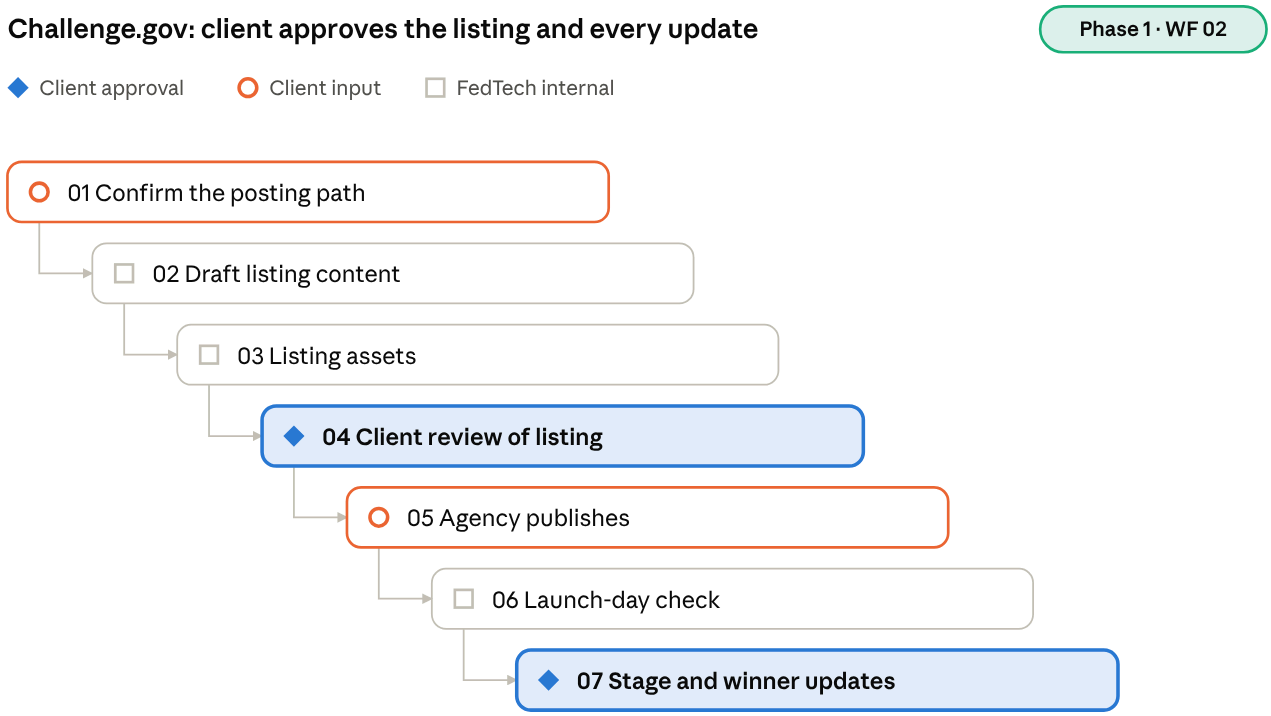
website build · 8 steps, 4 approval gates

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
1	Kickoff and requirements	Input	Confirm stage structure and dates from the RFTP; collect brand and logo rules; agree URL and hosting; inventory content	Brand guidelines, logos, URL preference, key dates
2	Sitemap and page plan	Approval	Page list; registration and submission flows per stage; what is public and what sits behind login	Sitemap, page list and user flows

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
3	Copy and official rules	Approval	Narrative, eligibility, prize and timeline copy; official rules including IP, indemnification and liability; launch FAQ	All copy, plus official rules after agency counsel review
4	Visual design	Approval	Wireframes; mockups in agency identity; contrast check	Homepage and interior mockups
5	Platform build and configuration	Input	Registration, eligibility screening and versioned submissions; reviewer portal and blinded scoring; analytics	Required submission fields and eligibility questions
6	QA and Section 508 audit	Internal	Browser and mobile checks; 508 audit; end-to-end form tests; check against approved copy	
7	Staging walkthrough and go-live	Approval	Guided walkthrough; one consolidated feedback round; confirm launch date	Go-live. Nothing publishes without it.
8	Launch and stage updates	Input	Publish and verify; coordinate the agency announcement; stage updates; rule changes go back through step 3	Announcement and press timing

02 Challenge.gov listing

The official federal listing, usually published through the agency's own Challenge.gov account and pointing to our site. It must match the site at every stage. Lead: Challenge Operations Lead. Client: COR and the agency's Challenge.gov manager.



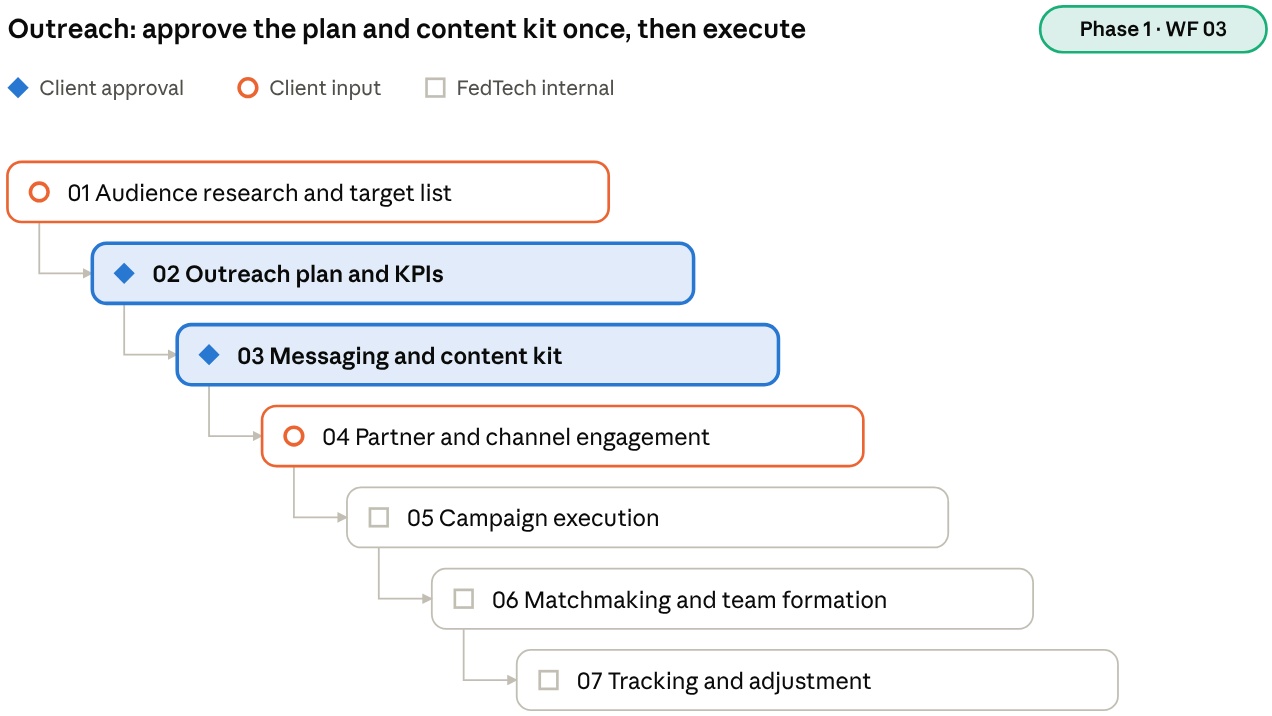
Challenge.gov listing · 7 steps, 2 approval gates

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
1	Confirm the posting path	Input	Find the agency's Challenge.gov manager; full listing or a summary linking to our site; confirm RFTP posting requirements	Challenge.gov contact and posting preference
2	Draft listing content	Internal	Adapt approved site copy to the listing fields; link to the challenge site	
3	Listing assets	Internal	Banner and logo sized to Challenge.gov specs; alt text; agency identity only	
4	Client review of listing	Approval	Full preview; dates, prizes and rules match the site word for word	Final listing text and images

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
5	Agency publishes	Input	Agency manager publishes, or grants FedTech access; timed with site launch	The publish action on the agency account
6	Launch-day check	Internal	Verify the live listing and links; cross-check against the site; share the URL with outreach	
7	Stage and winner updates	Approval	Update at each stage open and close; post winners; close the listing at the end	Each update, including the winner posting

03 Outreach and recruitment

The plan and campaign that bring the right solvers in. Recruit from a named target list, not a broadcast, and track participation from underrepresented institutions as a measured result. Lead: Outreach Lead. Client: COR and agency comms.

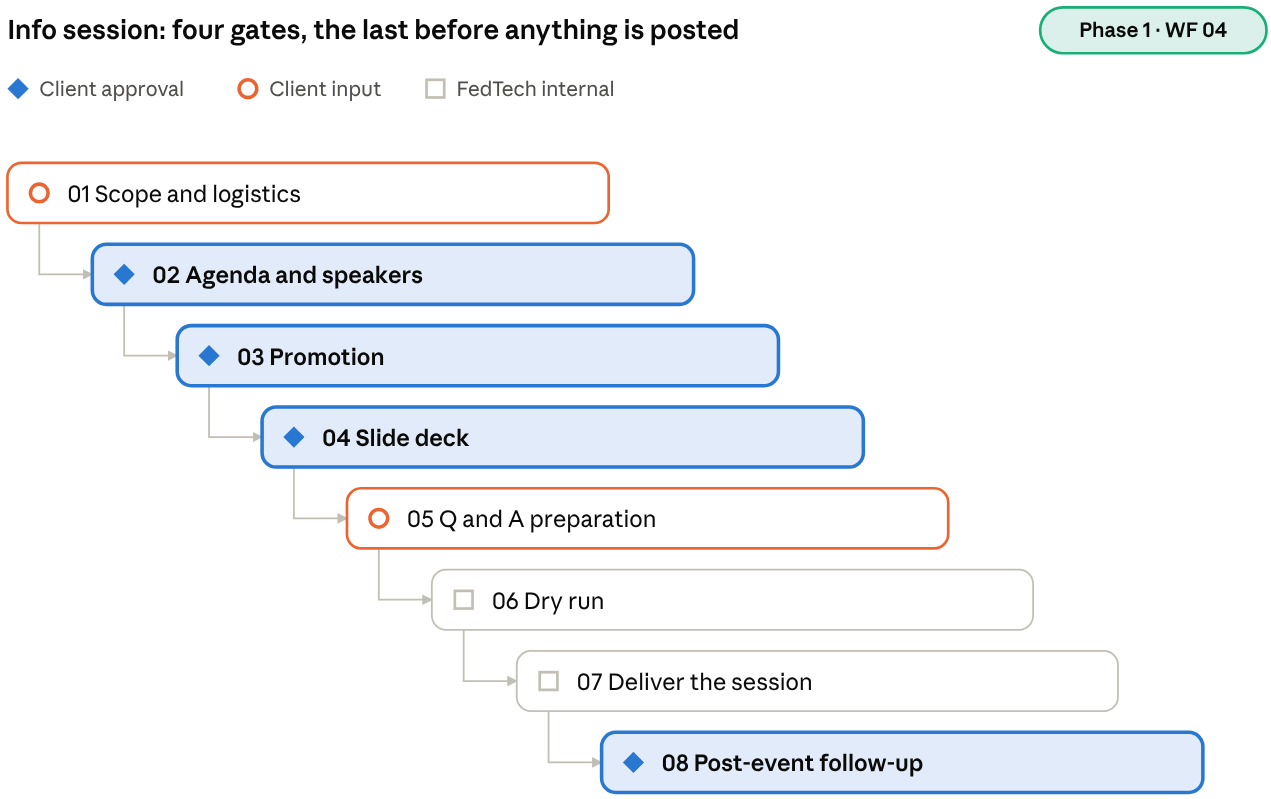


outreach and recruitment · 7 steps, 2 approval gates

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
1	Audience research and target list	Input	Map solver communities; named list of labs, companies and teams; past participants; HBCUs, MSIs and EPSCoR institutions	Known stakeholders, past participants, agency channels
2	Outreach plan	Approval	KPIs for registrations, submissions and diversity; channel plan; calendar tied to stage dates; matchmaking plan	Outreach plan and KPI targets
3	Messaging and content kit	Approval	Key messages; email, social and graphics; partner toolkit; all drawn from approved site copy	Messaging, templates and any use of agency name or logo
4	Partner and channel engagement	Input	Brief societies, consortia, tech-transfer offices and the SBIR/STTR community	Partner introductions; posts on agency channels
5	Campaign execution	Internal	Direct outreach to the target list; scheduled sends; promote sessions; deadline reminders	
6	Matchmaking and team formation	Internal	Partner-finding board; office hours; virtual mixers each stage	
7	Tracking and adjustment	Internal	Weekly metrics; shift effort to channels that convert; KPIs in monthly reports	

04 Info session

A public live session for prospective solvers: what the challenge is, who can enter, what's at stake and how to apply. Lead: Outreach Lead. Client: COR and agency speakers.



info session · 8 steps, 4 approval gates

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
1	Scope and logistics	Input	Date, time and audience; platform; registration; captioning and recording	Preferred dates, agency speakers, platform constraints
2	Agenda and speakers	Approval	Run of show; speaker roles; moderator and backup	Agenda and speaker lineup

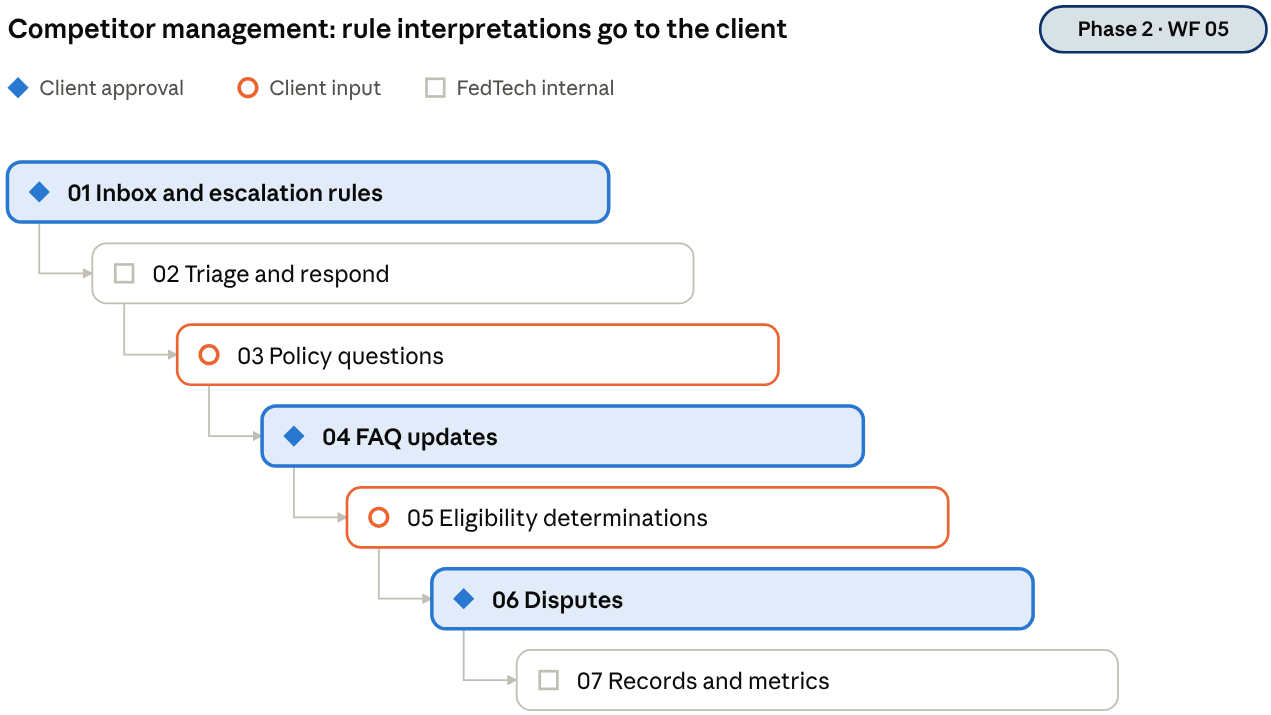
#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
3	Promotion	Approval	Registration page; email, social and newsletter copy; partner list; reminders	Promotional copy and any use of agency name or logo
4	Slide deck	Approval	Built from approved site copy; overview, timeline, eligibility, prizes, how to enter; speaker notes; 508-compliant	Final deck, content and branding
5	Q&A preparation	Input	Question bank from the inbox and FAQ log; draft answers; assign who answers what	Answers to policy and eligibility questions
6	Dry run	Internal	Timed rehearsal with agency speakers; test captions, polls and recording; backup plan	
7	Deliver the session	Internal	Host and moderate; captions and recording on; capture every question; defer uncertain answers to writing	
8	Post-event follow-up	Approval	Edit recording, captions and transcript; written answer to every question; FAQ update; attendance report	Recording, transcript and written answers before posting

Phase 2: Run the competition

Phase 2 keeps every solver on equal footing and turns submissions into award decisions. Its 8 gates guard rule interpretations, so a missed gate here can change the rules for one team and not another.

05 Competitor management

FedTech is the single point of contact for every solver question, eligibility determination and dispute. Most answers come from approved material; policy questions go to the client. Lead: Challenge Operations Lead. Client: COR.



competitor management · 7 steps, 3 approval gates

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
1	Inbox and escalation rules	Approval	Monitored inbox with a published response time; matrix of which questions go to the client; dispute process	Escalation matrix, response standard and dispute process
2	Triage and respond	Internal	Log every inquiry; answer from approved rules and FAQ only; route anything new	

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
3	Policy questions	Input	Send the client a draft answer, not just the question; hold the reply; queue it for the FAQ	Decisions on policy and rule interpretation
4	FAQ updates	Approval	Batch on a fixed schedule; post for all solvers; mirror to Challenge.gov if rules are affected	New FAQ entries that interpret the rules
5	Eligibility determinations	Input	Screen against published rules; decide clear cases; send borderline cases with a recommendation	Rulings on borderline cases
6	Disputes	Approval	Gather the facts; assess against the published rules; draft a resolution with its rationale	Each resolution before it is sent
7	Records and metrics	Internal	Audit-ready log of inquiries, decisions and disputes; response-time metrics; flag recurring questions	

06 Technical webinar

A deeper session for registered teams, led by subject-matter experts, on where solvers struggle most. The risk is a verbal clarification the rules don't support, so the content gate matters most. Lead: Review Lead with the Outreach Lead. Client: COR and agency technical leads.



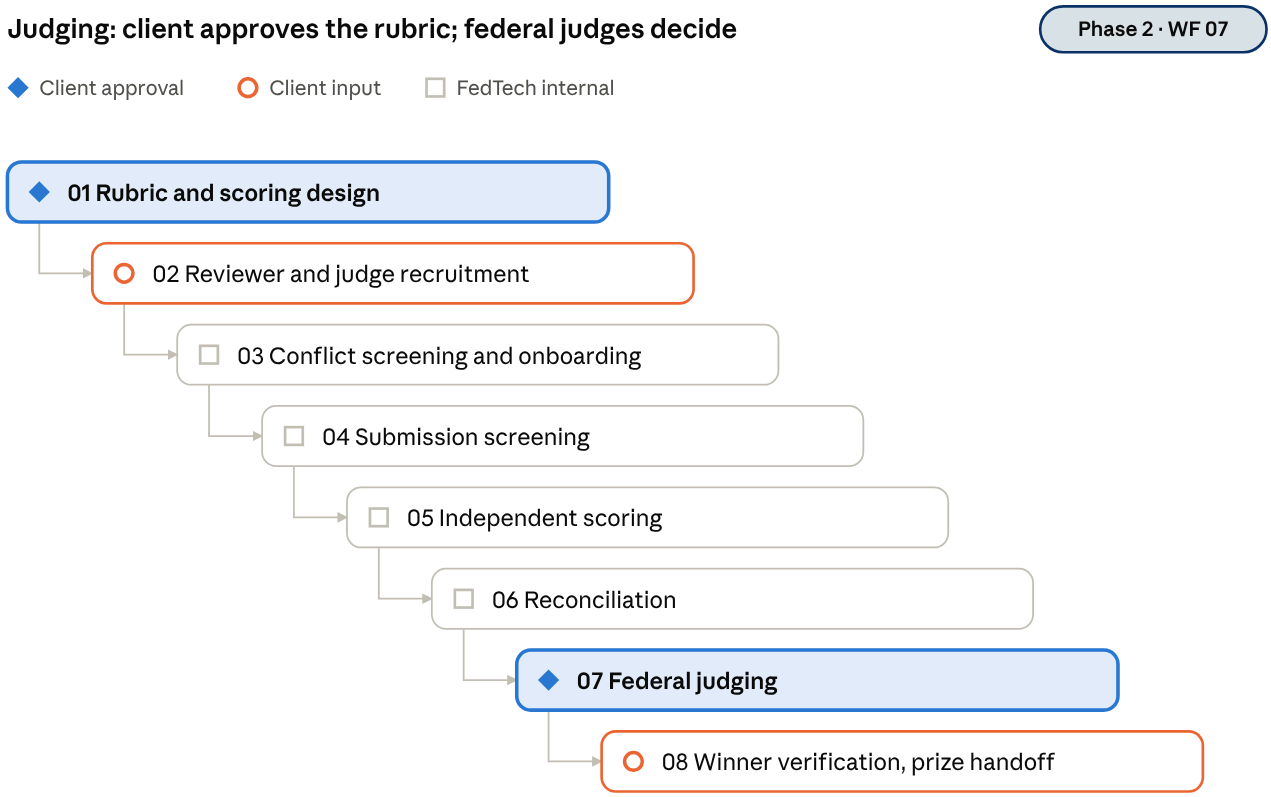
technical webinar · 7 steps, 3 approval gates

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
1	Define technical objectives	Input	Find where solvers struggle from the inbox, FAQ log and early submissions; set learning goals; pick a format	Technical priorities from agency technical leads
2	Presenters and conflict check	Approval	Identify SMEs; screen against reviewer and judge roles and the entrant list; confirm the brief	Presenter lineup

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
3	Technical content	Approval	Fit drafts to the template; check every claim against the rules and rubric; no new requirements verbally; 508-compliant	Technical accuracy and consistency with official rules
4	Promotion to registered teams	Internal	Targeted email; reuse templates approved for the info session; events page	
5	Rehearsal and demo check	Internal	Timing run; recorded fallback for live demos; Q&A roles; caption test	
6	Deliver the webinar	Internal	Host and moderate; SMEs answer technical questions; rules questions answered later in writing	
7	Publish written Q&A	Approval	Written answer to every question for all solvers; recording, slides and transcript; FAQ update	Written answers, which act as rule interpretations

07 Judging and technical review

Expert reviewers score against an approved rubric, and federal judges make every award decision. Its dates drive the winner announcement. Lead: Review Lead. Client: COR and federal judges.



judging and technical review · 8 steps, 2 approval gates

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
1	Rubric and scoring design	Approval	Criteria and weights per stage; scoring guidance; published criteria match the rubric	Rubric and weights, before the stage opens
2	Reviewer and judge recruitment	Input	SME reviewers per technical area; designated-country rules (FAR 52.225-5) if required; a bench deeper than the seats	Federal judge names and reviewer nominations
3	Conflict screening and onboarding	Internal	Conflict check against the entrant list every stage; NDAs; rubric training	

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
4	Submission screening	Internal	Completeness and compliance; entrant eligibility; reviewer assignment	
5	Independent scoring	Internal	Blind scores on the platform; track the deadline; backfill from the bench	
6	Reconciliation	Internal	Moderated session on divergent scores; a record of the discussion; score packet for judges	
7	Federal judging	Approval	Brief judges; facilitate the session; document decisions and rationale	Every award, decided by federal judges only
8	Winner verification and prize handoff	Input	Re-verify winner eligibility; payment details as the agency directs; hand the list to the announcement	Prize payment, usually made directly by the agency

Phase 3: Results and closeout

Phase 3 makes the results public and closes the task order. Its 9 gates are mostly about public content and contract deliverables.

08 Winner announcement

The public moment for each stage's results. Agency public affairs usually controls timing and clearance; our job is to have everything ready to release in the same hour on every channel. Lead: Outreach Lead. Client: COR and agency public affairs.

winner announcement · 7 steps, 1 approval gate

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
1	Announcement plan	Input	Target date, embargo and channels; public affairs clearance steps and lead time; who announces	Public affairs contact, clearance timeline, preferred date
2	Notify winners privately	Internal	Embargoed notice; collect bios, photos and team details; notify non-winners on release day	
3	Announcement content	Approval	Press release or blog; winner profiles and site update; social posts; Challenge.gov winner posting	All announcement content, through public affairs clearance
4	Winner consent	Internal	Winners confirm profiles and quotes; photo and name permissions; affiliations checked	
5	Coordinated release	Internal	Site, Challenge.gov and social together; email registrants and partners; verify links	
6	Amplification	Internal	Partner newsletters and society channels; approved content only; media inquiries to public affairs	

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
7	Results reporting	Internal	Reach and engagement metrics; press log; into the stage-close report	

09 In-person convening

An in-person event where winners present and meet the funders, adopters and program staff who can carry their work forward. Not every task order includes one. Lead: Outreach Lead. Client: COR and program leadership.

in-person convening · 8 steps, 4 approval gates

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
1	Goals and format	Input	What the event must achieve beyond showcasing; attendance and audience mix; length, region and date window	Goals, date constraints, leadership availability
2	Venue and logistics	Approval	Venue shortlist near agency stakeholders; AV, catering and accessibility; budget check against the task order	Venue and date, before any contract is signed
3	Agenda and speakers	Approval	Winner presentations; sessions with funders, SBIR/STTR staff and adopters; leadership remarks; networking	Agenda and speaker lineup
4	Invitations and registration	Input	Invite list; registration page; winner travel, if covered	Agency invitees and VIPs

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
5	Event materials	Approval	Program, signage, slide template and badges; accessible digital versions	All branded and printed materials
6	Run of show and rehearsal	Internal	Minute-by-minute run of show; presentation coaching; on-site AV walkthrough	
7	Deliver the event	Internal	Staff sessions; photos and recording with consent; capture contacts and introductions	
8	Follow-up and recap	Approval	Attendee survey; public recap; contact handoff to the agency	Public recap content before posting

10 Reporting and closeout

The contractual record of the challenge, from kickoff to the post-award evaluation survey. It runs behind every other workflow, and outreach metrics feed into it. Lead: Program Manager. Client: COR.

reporting and closeout · 7 steps, 4 approval gates

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
1	Kickoff and project plan	Approval	Kickoff with the COR; baselined schedule; report templates and cadence; reviewer and window for every gate	Project plan, schedule and report formats

#	Step	Type	What happens	Client signs off on or provides
2	Status calls	Internal	Weekly in active stages, biweekly otherwise; upcoming gates; any slip on a public date raised with options	
3	Monthly progress reports	Approval	Participation and outreach metrics; review status; risks and spend; inquiry metrics	Acceptance of each report
4	Stage-close reports	Approval	Submissions, scoring and winners; outreach and announcement results; lessons learned	Acceptance of each report
5	Post-award evaluation survey	Input	Survey of winners and participants after the final award; check Paperwork Reduction Act clearance; summarize results	Questions the agency needs answered
6	Network handoff package	Internal	SME and reviewer roster; stakeholder and partner contacts; records and platform data export	
7	Final report and closeout	Approval	Results and outcomes; survey findings; recommendations; close the site and listing	Final report, including the network handoff

New-PM checklist: first 30 days

Most slips on a challenge trace back to a gate nobody scheduled or an input nobody asked for. Clear these in the first 30 days after award.

- [ ] Read the RFTP and SOW; mark which of the ten workflows are in scope
- [ ] Hold the COR kickoff within the window the proposal committed to
- [ ] Name the client reviewer and review window for every approval gate in scope

- [ ] Build the schedule backward from each public date, including review windows
- [ ] Ask how long agency counsel needs for the official rules and how long public affairs needs for clearance; both run longer than a normal gate
- [ ] Confirm the Challenge.gov path and the agency's Challenge.gov manager
- [ ] Collect brand guidelines and logo-use rules
- [ ] Get federal judge names and confirm how prizes are paid
- [ ] Set up the solver inbox and get the escalation matrix approved before launch
- [ ] Ask whether the post-award survey needs Paperwork Reduction Act clearance, since that clearance can take months
- [ ] Agree the monthly report template with the COR
- [ ] Share this guide and the spec-sheet canvas with marketing

Adapting this guide to a new task order

The RFTP decides which of the ten workflows apply. Treat them as a menu, not a fixed package.

- **Remove** workflows that are out of scope. The convening is the one most often left out.
- **Add** a workflow the RFTP introduces by copying the blank template in the spec-sheet canvas, then add it here with the same diagram and table.
- **Check these against each RFTP:** stage structure and dates; which deliverables need COR approval; Section 508 language; designated-country rules for reviewers; how prizes are paid; the reporting cadence; any post-award evaluation.

This guide draws on the NOIS3-073 proposal and general federal challenge practice. The step-level detail is FedTech practice, not RFTP text, so confirm it on each new task order.